He (the attendant) said these words, ‘Blessed majesty, all the imperial forces were lost.
I’ve never seen such a catastrophic manifestation of divine will.’

When this terrible news was announced to Akbar, he was inconsolable. For two days and two nights he refused any food or water, did not attend to any state matters, left the bemused ambassador of Turan unattended, and turned away in grief from the jharoka window. Akbar ‘grieved him exceedingly, and his heart turned away from everything’, wrote Abu’l Fazl. Hamida Banu, who had come to the Punjab to meet with her son, had to entreat with the Padshah, along with his attendants, to resume his activities. The entire court mourned Birbal and the poet Keshavdas wrote verses in Brajbhasha in memory of him.

When Birbal passed away there was great rejoicing in
Poverty’s court.
The pakhavaj drums of Evil began to play
The sounds of the conch shells of Grief resounded
The songs of Falsehood, the tambourines of Fear
A concert of all these instruments was heard
The house of Kaliyuga was merry with the pipes of Discord and the streaming banners of Disgrace.

‘He never experienced such grief at the death of any Amir,’ wrote Badauni, ‘as he did at that of Birbal.’ Akbar seemed tormented by the idea of the broken, bloody body of his old friend lying unclaimed on the cold, stony hillsides on which he had died, carrying out his duty to his Padshah unto death. ‘Alas,’ he said, ‘that they could not bring his body out of the defile, that it might have been committed to the flames.’ In his grief and his fury he even wanted to rush to Kabul himself, to find Birbal’s body and to punish the other officers. He was dissuaded by his courtiers, and comforted by them with the idea that the light of the sun was enough to purify the body of his fallen friend. ‘By this heart-rending mishap, the memory of the pleasures of his lofty company has become very bitter,’ Akbar admitted to Abu’l Fazl, ‘and this sudden calamity has greatly afflicted my heart…some obstacles have prevented me from seeing the body with my own eyes so that I might testify my love and affection for him.’ Rumours circulated for the rest of the year, and even longer, that Birbal was not dead, that he had been seen, among jogis and sannyasis, or wandering in his old fief of